

specific asset allocation to meet those needs. As a person's situation changes, the manager will suggest appropriate changes in the asset allocation.

2. *Consistency of strategy.* Discipline is critical to investment success. Investors need to follow their plan and rebalance their portfolios on a regular basis. It is the job of an investment manager to ensure that this process happens.
3. *Create a circuit breaker.* During uncertain market conditions, some investors need to talk with someone about their concerns. A call to an advisor or financial planner usually calms an investor's nerves and stops the investor from making an emotionally incorrect decision.
4. *Place someone on duty 365 days per year.* There are times when all investors get sidetracked. An investment manager is there to do the investment chores for you all day, every day.

The biggest challenge when hiring an investment manager is finding a good one. Advisors come in all sizes, levels of competence, and investment philosophies. You'll likely be satisfied with your advisor if he or she is of like mind and charges reasonable fees. All else tends to be about style rather than substance.

Be careful about advisors who have ulterior motives. Many people in the business claim to be on your side, but they are actually selling investment products as a company rep. By definition, anyone who is compensated by commissions is not an advisor; such a person is selling. It is unrealistic to think that you will be offered unbiased investment advice under these circumstances.

Make sure you check the background information on a potential advisor on the Securities and Exchange Commission Web site at www.SEC.gov. If you have any question in your mind as to what a particular advisor's competence level is, go on to the next one.

Find out *exactly* how an advisor is paid and what that fee is. Advisors' fees should be fair, and there should be no conflicts of interest with the investments they use in client portfolios. An advisor should put all cost information in writing. Don't hire an advisor who will not line-item your costs. Are you are getting investment services; how much is that? Are you